11.8 Tilted Equilibria

WORKSHEET

The question

STEP III 2025, Question 9

Read the question before you go on. It is in the STEP III paper in OCR's download of the 2025 STEP papers (a zip file):

www.ocr.org.uk/Images/750486-2025-past-papers.zip

Hints

Try the question on your own first. If you get stuck, read the hints *one at a time*, and go back to the question after each one. Hints marked *Pause and try* are the key steps.

Ask yourself A solid rests on a table, touching at a single point X of its curved surface. The forces on it are its weight (acting at the centre of mass G) and the reaction at X. When are these in equilibrium?

STAGE 1 The centre of mass

Ask yourself Slice the solid into thin cylindrical shells of radius x, thickness δx and height y. What is the volume of a shell, and where is its centre of mass?

STAGE 2 Where normals meet the axis

Ask yourself For $n = 4$, $Y = r(1 - p^4 - \frac{1}{4p^2})$. Where is it greatest? What happens as $p \to 0$, and at $p = 1$?

STAGE 3 The spinning top

Ask yourself The solid in part (iii) is a dome ($n = 4$) on top of an upside-down paraboloid ($n = 2$). Where is its centre of mass?

STAGE 4 Counting equilibria

Ask yourself A tilted equilibrium needs a point (not A or B) whose normal passes through G. On each part of the surface, how many points have normals meeting the axis at height $\frac{3r}{35}$?

Try this next

1. **A self-righting toy.** Try STEP II 1996, Question 9 (step.maths.org/questions/96-s2-q9): when does a cone on a hemisphere right itself? (*Hint:* where must G be relative to the centre of the hemisphere?)

2. **A sphere.** For a uniform solid sphere, every normal passes through the centre. What does that say about its equilibria? What if the sphere's centre of mass is displaced slightly from its centre?

3. **An ellipse.** Show that an elliptical disc rolling in its own plane on a line has exactly four equilibria, and identify which are stable.

4 Two paraboloids. Replace the dome in part (iii) by a paraboloid $ry = r^2 - x^2$, so that the solid is symmetric about the x-axis. Show that G is at the origin, find the tilted equilibria, and explain why they come in pairs with equal tilts.

Further reading

- **Péter Várkonyi & Gábor Domokos, "Static equilibria of rigid bodies: dice, pebbles, and the Poincaré–Hopf theorem"**, *Journal of Nonlinear Science* 16 (2006). The Gömböc paper.
- **Daniel Kleppner & Robert Kolenkow, *An Introduction to Mechanics*** (Cambridge University Press), on equilibrium and stability.
- **Chris Rorres, "Completing Book II of Archimedes's *On Floating Bodies*"**, *Mathematical Intelligencer* 26 (2004). Archimedes' stability analysis, with modern pictures.

The full guided solution, and what the question leads to at university, is in Section 11.8:
https://beyondstep.keithmcnulty.org/ch11/tilted-equilibria.html